

■ By Shafi Rahman

**U**rban legend has it that a certain CPI(M) politburo member lives in the bunkers of AKG Bhavan, the party headquarters in Delhi, with no permission to travel beyond its premises. This bunker comrade—untainted by the world outside—provides the party its last word on ideological issues. As the CPA-Left relations went into a downward spiral through the year, and hit rock bottom with a resounding thud this week, it was clear that party General Secretary Prakash Karat had done at least one job well—that of imitating the intellectual aloofness of his imaginary colleague from the bunker and showing none of the pragmatism of his predecessors.

Not only did Karat miscalculate the Congress battle plan, but he also allowed natural ally Samajwadi Party (SP) to drift away and failed in living up to the mandate given to him in two consecutive Party Congresses in 2005 and 2008 to build up the Third Front. As he anchored his plans in a no-government-without-us belief, Karat, the policy wonk, saw his dream of being taken seriously as a street-smart politician dissolve as quickly as his party's plans to emerge as a national player.

Even as his comrades were perhaps busy mailing miss-you notes to Marxist veteran Harkishan Singh Surjeet, Karat tripped badly on delivering his baby, the Third Alternative. His grand statement to the cadre at the party's 19th Congress at Coimbatore in April that "on the nuclear deal also, we were able to rally the SP and the Telugu Desam Party", now sounds hollow with

**KARAT'S IDEOLOGICAL inflexibility may have failed the Congress at the Centre but it has kept his party relevant in Kerala and West Bengal.**

## The World According to Karat

SEPT 14, 2007 All relevant yet unspecified internal US laws such as the Hyde Act will directly impinge on the deal. The agreement does not give India any protection under international laws.

SEPT 19, 2007 The Hyde Act does not provide a "permanent" waiver as claimed by the Government. It is contingent upon "continued implementation" of certain commitments.

# Blind Left TURN

Led by an ideological purist obsessed with policy details, the CPI(M) finds itself ousted from the big political picture

Mulayam Singh Yadav opting for expediency over ideology.

"By raising common issues and initiating joint campaigns and struggles, the way can be paved for building a Third Alternative," he had told the Party Congress in April. But on the ground, he failed to cosy up to the SP on the nuclear deal. His party's push for the Women's Reservation Bill did nothing to better the relations, with Karat failing to understand SP's concerns in the Hindi heartland and playing to what one MP called "urban feminist slogans".

Even bigger problems lie ahead.

Mulayam's call to "strengthen secular forces" by joining Congress's fold leaves the CPI(M) with the unpleasant task of defining which is the bigger enemy—imperialism or communalism. Early this year, Karat himself had warned against BJP's politics, saying the Party Congress would work out "appropriate tactics" to isolate communal forces and prevent any opportunistic alliances for electoral gains. Now not only is Karat left waiting for the deal to happen, but he also runs the risk of seeing the BJP back in power at the Centre.

With Surjeet bedridden and Jyoti Basu now available only for birthday